

THE MF CONJECTURE IS FALSE: AN EXPLICIT FINITELY PRESENTED NON-MF GROUP

ANONYMOUS

ABSTRACT. A countable discrete group is MF here if it embeds in the unitary group of a norm matrix corona. We construct an explicit finitely presented group that is not MF, refuting the conjecture that every countable group is MF. Its reduced group C^* -algebra is a separable, stably finite C^* -algebra that is not MF, giving a concrete reduced group-algebra example rather than only an abstract existence result. The mechanism is a rigidity theorem for one-sided compressions of Kazhdan subgroups: in operator-norm matrix models, every compressor preserves the asymptotic commutant. Thus a certain commutator u converges to 1 in normalized Hilbert–Schmidt norm. A Clifford representation makes the central sign u^2 equal to -1 , giving the contradiction.

More generally, every finitely presented property-(T) group with a proper injective self-embedding produces a finitely presented non-MF group. We give an explicit eight-generator, forty-one-relator instance based on $\mathbb{Z}^3 \rtimes \mathrm{SL}_3(\mathbb{Z})$ and prove that its group rank is at most six. Its Clifford witness is a six-generated sofic non-MF group. Thus soficity does not imply MF, and MF groups are closed under neither quotients nor extensions. Its reduced group algebra is separable, exact, faithfully tracial, stably finite, and non-MF. The finite universal Horn obstruction also defines a nonempty clopen set of non-MF marked groups.

1 INTRODUCTION

Can every countable discrete group be realized by matrices, if multiplication is only required to hold up to operator-norm errors that vanish along a sequence of finite dimensions? Shulman calls the positive assertion the *MF conjecture* [Sh], and no group was known to fail it [Sc, Sh]. Residually finite groups satisfy it through their finite quotients, as do LEF groups [CDE] and, by quasidiagonality [TWW], all amenable groups; recent work establishes it for many amalgamated free products [Sc, Sh, GKEMP]. The corresponding C^* -algebra question is older: Blackadar and Kirchberg, who introduced MF algebras, remarked that no stably finite separable C^* -algebra was known not to be MF [BK, CDE], and their natural candidate $C_{\mathrm{red}}^*(F_2)$ was in fact proved MF by Haagerup and Thorbjørnsen [HT]. The negative solution of the Connes embedding problem subsequently supplied abstract stably finite

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non-MF algebras [JNVWY, FGH]. No countable group was known whose reduced or maximal group C^* -algebra fails to be MF [Sh].

These questions sit at the endpoint of a program of finitary approximation. In his 2018 ICM address, Thom asked for which Schatten p -norms there exist non-approximable groups [Th, Question 3.11]: the Frobenius case $p = 2$ was settled by De Chiffre–Glebsky–Lubotzky–Thom [DGLT], the cases $1 < p < \infty$ by Lubotzky–Oppenheim [LuO], and the case $p = 1$ by Bachner–Dogon–Lubotzky [BDL], who describe the three remaining metrics — the Hamming metric (soficity), the Hilbert–Schmidt norm (hyperlinearity), and the operator norm (MF) — as “the holy-grail of the subject.” The Hamming case was disproved in 2026: the first nonsofic group was constructed by OpenAI [OAI], Fournier-Facio then gave a torsion-free example [FFF], and Kun–Thom developed further wreath-product examples [KT26]. One-sided compression of a Kazhdan subgroup, the mechanism driving those arguments, is also the conceptual ancestor of the present one. Soficity concerns permutations in the Hamming metric, while MF concerns unitaries in operator norm, so there is no direct metric comparison between the two approximation properties. The operator-norm setting requires a different rigidity theorem, proved here by applying the Kazhdan projection inside a finite norm ultraproduct. This paper settles the operator-norm case by one explicit finitely presented group; it also proves that soficity does not imply MF and produces an explicit reduced group C^* -algebra that is stably finite but not MF. Of the three problems, only the Hilbert–Schmidt case — hyperlinearity — remains open.

Let $(d_n)_{n \in \mathbb{N}}$ be a sequence of positive integers and let

$$(1) \quad \mathcal{Q} = \prod_n M_{d_n}(\mathbb{C}) / \bigoplus_n M_{d_n}(\mathbb{C})$$

be the associated *norm matrix corona*: bounded sequences of matrices modulo sequences converging to 0 in operator norm. Following Blackadar–Kirchberg [BK], a separable C^* -algebra is *MF* if it embeds into some algebra of the form (1). We use *MF group* exclusively in the sense introduced by Carrión–Dadarlat–Eckhardt and used by Shulman and Bachner–Dogon–Lubotzky [CDE, Sh, BDL]: a countable discrete group E is MF if, for some strictly increasing sequence of positive integers (d_n) , there is an injective homomorphism

$$E \longrightarrow \mathcal{U}(\mathcal{Q}).$$

We shall use the equivalent coordinate model

$$(2) \quad \mathcal{U}_{\text{cor}}((d_n)) := \prod_n \mathcal{U}(M_{d_n}(\mathbb{C})) / \{(u_n) : \|u_n - 1\| \rightarrow 0\}.$$

The denominator is normal, and polar correction gives a canonical isomorphism

$$(3) \quad \kappa_{(d_n)} : \mathcal{U}_{\text{cor}}((d_n)) \xrightarrow{\cong} \mathcal{U}(\mathcal{Q}),$$

proved in Lemma 4.2. Thus one may equivalently embed E into $\mathcal{U}_{\text{cor}}((d_n))$.

Proposition 1.1 (equivalent MF formulations). *For every countable group, the genuine C^* -corona definition above is equivalent to the unitary-sequence definition. The latter is equivalent to operator-norm local models with separation constant 1, and allowing arbitrary positive dimensions is equivalent to requiring the dimensions to be strictly increasing.* [formalized in Lean]

The routine amplification proof, together with the precise formulation of the operator-norm local models, is deferred to Appendix A.

Hereafter “MF” means this equivalent actual-corona/local-operator-norm property. It should not be confused with stronger reduced-norm conventions. In [GKEMP], the approximating maps must additionally recover both the canonical trace and the left-regular norm on every group-ring element. The purely matricial field (PMF) convention of [MdlS, Definition 1.2] instead requires genuine finite-dimensional representations whose group-ring norms converge to the regular norms; trace convergence is included in some related conventions but not in that definition. Every assertion below uses only the MF property fixed here.

Throughout, $[g, h] = ghg^{-1}h^{-1}$ for group elements, while for matrices $[x, y] = xy - yx$; the arguments always make the reading unambiguous.

2 ONE-SIDED KAZHDAN TRANSPORT

The rigidity mechanism is best remembered before the construction. The same elementary principle appears in three finite worlds:

$$\begin{array}{ccc} X \subseteq Y, |X| = |Y| & V \subseteq W, \dim V = \dim W & \begin{array}{c} p \leq q, p \sim q \\ \text{in a finite } C^*\text{-algebra} \end{array} \\ \Downarrow & \Downarrow & \Downarrow \\ X = Y & V = W & p = q. \end{array}$$

Finite-dimensional representations use the middle implication directly. For norm-matrix coronas, property (T) supplies a Kazhdan projection in a finite norm ultraproduct, and the right-hand implication turns its one-sided inclusion into equality. This yields the reusable theorem behind every result below.

We use the following terminology before collecting the remaining notation in Section 4. A *corona representation* of a group H is a homomorphism $H \rightarrow \mathcal{U}(\mathcal{Q})$, and it *detects* $g \in H$ when it does not send g to 1. An *operator-norm asymptotic representation* is a sequence of maps $U_n: H \rightarrow \mathcal{U}(d_n)$ such that

$$\|U_n(g)U_n(h) - U_n(gh)\| \longrightarrow 0 \quad (g, h \in H).$$

For coordinate sequences, $a_n \sim_2 b_n$ means $\|a_n - b_n\|_2 \rightarrow 0$, where $\|x\|_2 = \text{tr}_{d_n}(x^*x)^{1/2}$ is the normalized Hilbert–Schmidt norm.

Theorem 2.1 (Kazhdan transport of asymptotic commutants). *Let Γ and H be groups, let Γ have property (T), let $\iota: \Gamma \rightarrow H$ be a homomorphism, let $s \in H$, and let (d_n) be a sequence of positive integers. Suppose*

$$s\iota(\Gamma)s^{-1} \subseteq \iota(\Gamma).$$

Let $U_n: H \rightarrow \mathcal{U}(d_n)$ be an operator-norm asymptotic representation. If (x_n) is uniformly operator-norm bounded and

$$\|[x_n, U_n(\iota(\gamma))]\|_2 \longrightarrow 0 \quad (\gamma \in \Gamma),$$

then

$$\|[U_n(s)x_nU_n(s)^*, U_n(\iota(\gamma))]\|_2 \longrightarrow 0 \quad (\gamma \in \Gamma).$$

[formalized in Lean]

Proof. Argue by contradiction: fix $\gamma_0 \in \Gamma$ and pass to a subsequence on which the asserted commutator norms for γ_0 stay bounded away from zero. Fix a free ultrafilter ω on that subsequence, put $K_n = L^2(M_{d_n}(\mathbb{C}), \text{tr}_{d_n})$, and form the Hilbert ultraproduct K_ω . The adjoint actions define an honest unitary representation

$$\pi(g) = (\text{Ad } U_n(g))_\omega \quad (g \in H)$$

on K_ω . They also belong to the norm ultraproduct

$$B_\omega = \prod_{\omega} B(K_n).$$

Its natural action on K_ω is faithful (choose coordinate unit vectors which almost attain the operator norms). Moreover B_ω is finite: if $v^*v = 1$, polar correction replaces any representing sequence for v by unitaries along ω , so $vv^* = 1$.

Let $p_\Gamma \in C_{\max}^*(\Gamma)$ be the Kazhdan projection [BHV], let $\pi_\Gamma = \pi \circ \iota$, put $P = \pi_\Gamma(p_\Gamma) \in B_\omega$ using the integrated form of π_Γ , and write $V = \pi(s)$. The range of P is the fixed space $K_\omega^{\iota(\Gamma)}$. The one-sided compression gives

$$PK_\omega = K_\omega^{\iota(\Gamma)} \subseteq K_\omega^{s\iota(\Gamma)s^{-1}} = VPK_\omega, \quad \text{so} \quad P \leq VPV^*.$$

The two projections are unitarily equivalent in the finite algebra B_ω ; hence

$$\boxed{P = VPV^*}.$$

Indeed, writing $VPV^* = Q$ and $r = V^*Q$, one has $r^*r = Q$ and $rr^* = P \leq Q$, so $\sigma = r + (1 - Q)$ satisfies $\sigma^*\sigma = 1$ and $\sigma\sigma^* = P + (1 - Q)$; finiteness of B_ω forces $\sigma\sigma^* = 1$, that is, $P = Q$. Uniform boundedness makes $x = (x_n)_\omega$ a vector in K_ω , and the hypothesis says $x \in PK_\omega$. Therefore $Vx \in PK_\omega$, contrary to the choice of γ_0 and the subsequence. This proves the ordinary, rather than merely ultrafilter, convergence asserted in the theorem. $\square$

Central-corner reduction. Let $\Theta: H \rightarrow \mathcal{U}(\mathcal{Q})$ be a corona representation and let $0 \neq q \in \mathcal{Q}$ be a projection commuting with $\Theta(H)$. Then $\Theta_q(g) = q\Theta(g)q$ is a homomorphism into the unitary group of the corner $q\mathcal{Q}q$, whose unit is q , and this corner is itself a positive-rank norm matrix corona. Indeed, a spectral cut at $1/2$ of a self-adjoint lift of q gives coordinate projections (q_n) representing q . Put $r_n = \text{rank } q_n$. Nonzeroness makes $J = \{n : r_n > 0\}$ infinite. Compression identifies $q_n M_{d_n}(\mathbb{C}) q_n$ with $M_{r_n}(\mathbb{C})$ on J ; the zero coordinates contribute nothing, and relabeling J by $\mathbb{N}$ identifies $q\mathcal{Q}q$ with a corona of positive matrix ranks. Compression of Θ is multiplicative because

q is central relative to its image, and unitary coordinate lifts follow by polar correction.

The entire non-MF argument is the following consequence, applied to the two-element central subgroup $\{1, \varepsilon\}$.

Theorem 2.2 (central-sign criterion). *Let H and Γ be countable groups, let Γ have property (T), let $\iota: \Gamma \rightarrow H$ be a homomorphism, and suppose*

$$t\iota(\Gamma)t^{-1} \subseteq \iota(\Gamma), \quad [c, \iota(\Gamma)] = 1.$$

Put $d = tct^{-1}$ and $u = [d, \iota(a)]$ for some $a \in \Gamma$. If

$$\varepsilon = u^2 \neq 1, \quad \varepsilon^2 = 1, \quad \varepsilon \in Z(H),$$

then every homomorphism from H to a norm matrix corona kills ε , and H is not MF. [formalized in Lean]

Proof. Suppose a corona representation Θ detects ε , that is, $\Theta(\varepsilon) \neq 1$. The nonzero projection, central relative to $\Theta(H)$,

$$q = \frac{1 - \Theta(\varepsilon)}{2}$$

cuts it to a representation in which $\Theta(\varepsilon) = -1$. The central-corner reduction above regards this as a representation into a positive-rank norm matrix corona. The element c belongs to the asymptotic commutant of $\iota(\Gamma)$, so Theorem 2.1 puts $d = tct^{-1}$ there as well. Hence $u = [d, \iota(a)] \sim_2 1$, and therefore $\varepsilon = u^2 \sim_2 1$. On the q -corner, however, $\varepsilon = -1$, whose normalized Hilbert–Schmidt distance from 1 is 2. This contradiction kills ε in every corona representation; since $\varepsilon \neq 1$, no such representation is faithful. $\square$

This is the proof to keep in mind.

3 THE KAZHDAN–CLIFFORD CONSTRUCTION

Given Γ, α, a as in the theorem below, the construction is most readable with one redundant generator ε : declare it to be a central involution and impose

$$(4) \quad \boxed{\varepsilon = u^2, \quad u = [tct^{-1}, a].}$$

This is the conceptual presentation: rigidity forces $u \sim_2 1$, whereas the Clifford model makes $u^2 = -1$. The theorem below uses the Tietze-eliminated version. Since $d = tct^{-1}$ is an involution, $u^2 = [d, ada^{-1}]$; conversely, centrality of u^2 forces $(u^2)^2 = 1$. Thus the redundant sign costs one generator and saves the reader the only opaque word in the construction.

Theorem 3.1 (Kazhdan–Clifford construction). *Let Γ be a finitely presented group with property (T), let $\alpha: \Gamma \hookrightarrow \Gamma$ be an injective endomorphism, and choose $a \in \Gamma \setminus \alpha(\Gamma)$. Adjoin elements t, c and impose*

$$t\gamma t^{-1} = \alpha(\gamma), \quad c^2 = 1, \quad [c, \gamma] = 1 \quad (\gamma \in \Gamma).$$

Put

$$d = tct^{-1}, \quad u = [d, a], \quad w = u^2 = [d, ada^{-1}],$$

and impose centrality of w . More explicitly, for a finite generating set S_Γ it is enough to impose the compression and lamp relations for $s \in S_\Gamma$, together with

$$[w, s] = 1 \quad (s \in S_\Gamma), \quad [w, t] = [w, c] = 1.$$

Thus w commutes with a generating set of the entire resulting group. The group $E(\Gamma, \alpha, a)$ is finitely presented, the canonical map $\Gamma \rightarrow E(\Gamma, \alpha, a)$ is injective, and w is a nontrivial central involution. Every homomorphism

$$E(\Gamma, \alpha, a) \longrightarrow \mathcal{U}(\mathcal{Q})$$

to the unitary group of every norm matrix corona kills w . Consequently $E(\Gamma, \alpha, a)$ is not MF. [formalized in Lean]

Proof. Finite presentability follows from a relative finite presentation: start with the free product of Γ and the free group on t, c , and quotient by the finitely many displayed relations for a finite generating set of Γ .

The relation $w^2 = 1$ is redundant. Put $b = ada^{-1}$. Both d and b are involutions, $w = [d, b] = (db)^2$, and direct cancellation gives

$$(5) \quad dwd^{-1} = w^{-1}.$$

Centrality also gives $dwd^{-1} = w$, whence $w = w^{-1}$ and $w^2 = 1$.

For nontriviality, realize the ascending HNN extension

$$G = \langle \Gamma, t \mid t\gamma t^{-1} = \alpha(\gamma) \rangle$$

as a mapping telescope. Let Γ_∞ be the direct limit of the system $\Gamma \xrightarrow{\alpha} \Gamma \xrightarrow{\alpha} \cdots$; injectivity of α passes to the limit, so the level-zero map embeds Γ in Γ_∞ . Applying α levelwise induces an *automorphism* σ of Γ_∞ : it is injective, and it is surjective because an element at level k equals σ of the same element at level $k + 1$. Put $G = \Gamma_\infty \rtimes_\sigma \mathbb{Z}$, with stable letter t implementing σ ; then $t\gamma t^{-1} = \alpha(\gamma)$ for $\gamma \in \Gamma$, and we write $X = G/\Gamma$ for the coset space of the level-zero copy. Let G permute the Clifford generators $(e_x)_{x \in X}$ and map c to e_Γ . Then

$$d \mapsto e_{t\Gamma}, \quad ada^{-1} \mapsto e_{at\Gamma}.$$

The two cosets are distinct: equality would give $t^{-1}at \in \Gamma$, equivalently $a \in \alpha(\Gamma)$. Hence the two Clifford generators anticommute and

$$w \mapsto (e_{t\Gamma}e_{at\Gamma})^2 = -1.$$

The Clifford sign is central, so the map respects every defining relation. It follows simultaneously that $w \neq 1$ and that the canonical map of Γ is injective.

Finally, $w = u^2$ is a nontrivial central involution. The central-sign criterion therefore says that every corona representation kills w . Since $w \neq 1$, none is faithful. $\square$

The sign argument has a useful Clifford-free strengthening. For a subgroup $L \leq H$, let $G_{\text{comp}}(L)$ be generated by the elements s satisfying $sLs^{-1} \subseteq L$, and put

$$(6) \quad \mathfrak{D}(H, L) = \left\langle\left\langle [gzg^{-1}, \ell] : g \in G_{\text{comp}}(L), z \in C_H(L), \ell \in L \right\rangle\right\rangle_H.$$

Theorem 9.4 in Section 9 upgrades the sign criterion to this intrinsic defect: in the presence of a property-(T) subgroup $L = \iota(\Gamma)$, every finite normal subgroup of H contained in $\mathfrak{D}(H, L)$ is killed by every corona representation of H .

The same element a drives both halves of the proof. Analytically, $a \in \Gamma$, so fixed-space transport forces the displaced lamp to commute with its image in finite-dimensional norm models. Geometrically, $a \notin \alpha(\Gamma)$, so a moves that lamp to a different HNN coset, where Clifford anticommutation produces -1 . Thus a lives on the boundary of the self-compression: rigidity cannot detect that boundary, while the Clifford representation detects it by a sign.

The following theorem is the fully explicit instance, developed in Sections 5–7.

Theorem A (explicit Kazhdan–Clifford group). *Let E be the group on the eight generators $v_1, v_2, v_3, x, y, z, t, c$ with the forty-one relators displayed in Definition 5.1. Put*

$$w = [tct^{-1}, v_1(tct^{-1})v_1^{-1}].$$

The defining relations make w central; together with $c^2 = 1$, centrality implies $w^2 = 1$. Then:

- (1) *$w \neq 1$ in E , so w is a central involution;*
- (2) *for every sequence (d_n) of positive integers and every group homomorphism $\Theta: E \rightarrow \text{U}_{\text{cor}}((d_n))$ into the corresponding unitary norm corona (2), one has $\Theta(w) = 1$.*

In particular E is not MF, and neither $C_{\text{max}}^(E)$ nor $C_{\text{red}}^*(E)$ is an MF C^* -algebra. [formalized in Lean]*

The exponent 2 is not special. For $m \geq 2$, let E_m be the same eight-generator presentation, replacing the three relations $tv_it^{-1} = v_i^2$ by $tv_it^{-1} = v_i^m$ and leaving every other relator unchanged; thus $E_2 = E$. Write w_m for the image of the same marked word w .

Corollary 3.2 (the scaling family). *For every natural number $m \geq 2$, the group E_m is finitely presented and w_m is a nontrivial central involution killed by every homomorphism from E_m to every unitary norm matrix corona. Consequently E_m is not MF, and neither $C_{\text{max}}^*(E_m)$ nor $C_{\text{red}}^*(E_m)$ is an MF C^* -algebra. [formalized in Lean]*

Proof. Replace the affine dilation $\text{diag}(2, 2, 2, 1)$ by $\text{diag}(m, m, m, 1)$ (both acting as in Lemma 6.2). It conjugates each integral translation v_i to v_i^m and fixes the three linear generators. Its inverse sends v_1 to translation by e_1/m , which is not integral; hence the two Clifford sites remain distinct and

w_m maps to -1 . The Kazhdan base, the one-sided compression argument, and the central-sign criterion are independent of m . $\square$

For the proof, put $d = tct^{-1}$ and $u = [d, v_1]$. Lemma 7.1 gives the useful identity $w = u^2$. The proof has two opposed halves, both centered on u :

$$\boxed{\text{matrix-corona rigidity: } u \sim_2 1} \quad \text{and} \quad \boxed{\text{Clifford model: } u^2 = -1.}$$

For a corona representation that detects w , cut to the negative central corner of w . Kazhdan transport gives $u \sim_2 1$, hence $w = u^2 \sim_2 1$; the corner identity gives $w = -1$. This contradiction is the analytic core of Theorem A: Section 7 deduces the theorem from the sign criterion and the witness, and Section 9 proves the general finite-normal criterion. [formalized in Lean]

Nontriviality of w is witnessed by a completely explicit representation of E into a semidirect product of a Clifford group by a mapping-telescope group built from exact affine matrices over $\mathbb{Z}[1/2]$ (Section 6); no combinatorial theory of HNN extensions is needed.

Two companion results clarify the mechanism. First, in finite dimensions the obstruction is elementary and needs neither property (T), nor unitarity, nor centrality of w ; it kills the entire intrinsic defect (6):

Theorem B (finite-dimensional shadow). *Let k be a field, V a finite-dimensional k -vector space, H a group, $\Gamma \leq H$ a subgroup, and $t, c \in H$, $a \in \Gamma$ elements with $t\Gamma t^{-1} \subseteq \Gamma$ and $c\gamma = \gamma c$ for all $\gamma \in \Gamma$. Then every homomorphism $\pi: H \rightarrow \text{GL}(V)$ satisfies*

$$\pi([tct^{-1}, a(tct^{-1})a^{-1}]) = 1.$$

More generally, every such π sends the entire subgroup $\mathfrak{D}(H, \Gamma)$ to the identity.

[formalized in Lean]

Applied to $H = E$, Theorem B shows that *every* finite-dimensional representation of E over *every* field sends w to the identity: finite-dimensional linear representations do not separate the points of E , no finite quotient can witness $w \neq 1$, and the infinite Clifford witness of Section 6 cannot be replaced by a finite-dimensional one. In the terminology of [BDL, Definition 1.2], the central involution w , invisible in every finite quotient, makes E a group of *Deligne type*; such groups were proposed there as the natural candidate counterexamples for all three remaining approximation problems, and E realizes that proposal at the operator-norm endpoint. Property (T) enters the corona argument through the Kazhdan projection for the adjoint representation on the Hilbert ultraproduct. Finiteness of the accompanying norm ultraproduct turns the one-sided inclusion of fixed spaces into equality.

Second, the elementary finite-dimensional calculation does not determine whether its marked word is trivial:

Theorem C (cyclic-base calibration). *Define the literal marked presentation*

$$E_{\text{BS}} = \left\langle \gamma_0, t, c \left| \begin{array}{l} t\gamma_0 t^{-1} = \gamma_0^2, \quad c^2 = 1, \quad [c, \gamma_0] = 1, \\ w_{\text{BS}}^2 = 1, \quad [w_{\text{BS}}, \gamma_0] = [w_{\text{BS}}, t] = [w_{\text{BS}}, c] = 1 \end{array} \right. \right\rangle,$$

where $w_{\text{BS}} = [tct^{-1}, \gamma_0(tct^{-1})\gamma_0^{-1}]$. Then E_{BS} is finitely presented and $w_{\text{BS}} \neq 1$. There is an explicit surjective homomorphism from E_{BS} onto its realized Clifford quotient that maps w_{BS} to the nontrivial central sign. Nevertheless every finite-dimensional representation of E_{BS} over every field maps w_{BS} to the identity. [formalized in Lean]

The quotient statement makes the comparison at the level actually used by the proof: exact finite-dimensional invisibility does not by itself force triviality of the marked word. The MF conclusion in Theorem A is the separate uniform assertion supplied by the fixed-space argument.

Generalizations and consequences Theorem A is an instance of a general finite-normal obstruction (Definition 9.1). A marked Kazhdan pattern consists of a property (T) group Λ , a homomorphism $\iota: \Lambda \rightarrow H$, and elements $t, c \in H$ such that $t\iota(\Lambda)t^{-1} \subseteq \iota(\Lambda)$ and $[c, \iota(\Lambda)] = 1$. Theorem 9.2 sends every finite normal subgroup contained in the resulting compression-defect subgroup to the identity under every corona representation. For E , the relevant subgroup is $\{1, w\}$. Corollary 10.5 records the resulting obstruction for C^* -subalgebras of norm matrix coronas, while Theorem C shows that finite-dimensional collapse by itself does not decide whether the marked word is trivial. The same instance yields a finite universal Horn sentence valid in every MF group and falsified by E , hence a nonempty clopen set of non-MF marked groups (Proposition 10.6 and Corollary 10.7), and the failures of quotient and extension permanence (Corollary 10.11 and Section 10).

Section 10 develops structural and C^* -algebraic consequences, including a finitely generated sofic non-MF group and failures of quotient and extension permanence. Every MF algebra is stably finite [BK], so Theorem D exhibits a separable stably finite C^* -algebra that is not MF. Abstract examples follow from the failure of the Connes embedding problem [FGH]; the point here is concreteness: the algebra is the reduced group C^* -algebra of an explicit finitely presented group. Even for $C_{\text{red}}^*(\text{SL}_3(\mathbb{Z}))$ and $C_{\text{red}}^*(\text{SL}_4(\mathbb{Z}))$ the MF property is undecided; only the stronger PMF property is known to fail, for $\text{SL}_4(\mathbb{Z})$ [Mdis]. Our example has the following properties:

Theorem D (the reduced group algebra of E). $C_{\text{red}}^*(E)$ is a unital separable C^* -algebra which carries a faithful tracial state — and is therefore stably finite — but is not an MF algebra. [formalized in Lean]

The canonical homomorphism $\mathcal{B} \rightarrow E$ is injective: composing it with the homomorphism $E \rightarrow W$ of Proposition 6.3 gives $g \mapsto j(\bar{g})$, and $\mathcal{B} \rightarrow \bar{\Gamma}$ is injective by Proposition 5.2 together with Lemma 6.2. Since the infinite Kazhdan group $\mathcal{B}$ is nonamenable, so is E . Hence $C_{\text{red}}^*(E)$ is not nuclear [Lan]. The nuclear form of the Blackadar–Kirchberg problem — whether every stably finite separable nuclear C^* -algebra is quasidiagonal — is therefore untouched by Theorem D.

Operator norm versus tracial approximation The argument is specific to operator norm: operator-norm multiplicative defects make the adjoint

actions into an honest representation on the Hilbert ultraproduct. Hilbert–Schmidt-small defects alone do not provide that operator control, so the proof does not give a hyperlinear obstruction.

Group-theoretic inputs The proof of Theorem A uses two external sources: the displayed presentation of $\mathrm{SL}_3(\mathbb{Z})$ from [CRW], and [BHV] for both property (T) of $\mathbb{Z}^3 \rtimes \mathrm{SL}_3(\mathbb{Z})$ and the Kazhdan projection. Later consequences use quasidiagonality of amenable groups [TWW], Mal’cev residual finiteness for finitely generated linear groups, the sofic permanence results of Elek–Szabó [ES06], and their simple sofic embedding theorem [ES05]. The exact twenty-relator base is identified with that affine group in Section 5; the Clifford witness and finite-dimensional obstruction are proved directly.

Formal verification Each gray “formalized in Lean” tag marks a closed theorem in the accompanying Lean 4 development with the same outer proposition as the printed statement. The formal track has no theorem inputs: in particular it derives property (T) of the literal twenty-relator base from an explicit rational spectral certificate rather than importing [CRW] or [BHV]. Untagged literature consequences, including the soficity calculation below, remain deliberately outside that claim. The public version of each tag links to the corresponding declaration on the reviewed source branch.

Relation to prior work The closest conceptual analogue is the recent work on nonsofic groups. One-sided compression of a property (T) subgroup and propagation from its centralizer appear in [OAI, KT26], building on rigidity results of Kun and Kun–Thom [Ku16, KT19]; related centralizer rigidity for sofic embeddings is proved in [AT]. Those results concern Hamming or tracial approximations. Here the adjoint actions produce a Hilbert ultraproduct representation, the Kazhdan projection is carried by a finite norm ultraproduct, and finiteness prevents a one-sided compression from enlarging its range. The complementary finite-group corner then converts that rigidity into a fixed nontrivial element sent to the identity by every corona representation. The Clifford central extension supplies the element whose survival is proved independently. The results of [OAI, KT26] provide context only: no theorem in this paper uses either one as an input.

Slofstra’s constructions supply close precedents for the Clifford group, distinguished central involution, shift, and HNN doubling map [Slo18, Section 2 and Remark 3.3]. Negative-eigenspace compression appears in Slofstra–Vidick [SV, proof of Proposition 2.7], and Bachner–Dogon–Lubotzky develop operator-norm rounding, compression, and polar-correction procedures in detail [BDL, Lemmas 2.2–2.3, Proposition 2.4, and the proof of Proposition 1.5]. That local procedure enters the finite-normal corner reduction below; the transport step itself is the finite-norm-ultraproduct argument of Theorem 2.1.

The analytic passage from operator norm to the Hilbert–Schmidt conjugation representation belongs to the $\pi \otimes \bar{\pi}$ framework of Bekka and Bekka–Valette [Be, BV]. Dadarlat uses normalized finite-rank projections as almost invariant Hilbert–Schmidt vectors in an operator-norm approximation argument [Dad, Lemma 3.18 and Proposition 3.19]. These are the direct analytic precedents for the conjugation step used here.

Slofstra’s quotients by elements invisible to exact or approximate finite-dimensional representations precede the MF-radical language used below [Slo17, Definitions 2.5–2.7]. Fritz’s marked BS(2, 3) example provides additional context for the cyclic comparison [Fri, SV].

Central extensions and rigidity of approximate representations also drive the Frobenius obstruction of De Chiffre–Glebsky–Lubotzky–Thom [DGLT]. In the proof of Proposition 1.6, Bachner–Dogon–Lubotzky treat the finite-central case by a character-isotypic corner, and reduce the general finite-normal case to it by passing to the finite-index centralizer [BDL]. The finite-normal criterion here combines the corresponding coordinate-corner construction with the one-sided Kazhdan compressor and does not assume that the quotient is hyperlinear. Related finite-target approximation and extension results for weak soficity appear in [GR, Gl].

Carrión–Dadarlat–Eckhardt provide the group-MF framework used here and, through Abels’ group, an amenable MF group that is not residually finite [CDE, Section 2.14 and Corollary 2.18]. The cyclic comparison addresses the narrower question of what happens to the marked compression pattern when property (T) is removed.

Finally, failure of the MF property for a group C^* -algebra does not by itself prevent the group from embedding into a corona: the group property requires only a faithful canonical image in some MF quotient of $C_{\max}^*(E)$. The result here produces a specific nontrivial element in the kernel of every such representation. For broader context see [DGLT, BDL, OAI, KT26, Sh, Dad, Slo17, Slo18, SV].

Organization Sections 2–3 isolate the analytic mechanism and the general construction. Section 4 fixes notation, proves the corona lifting lemmas, and states the conventions. Section 5 constructs E and proves property (T) for its literal base. Section 6 proves $w \neq 1$. Section 7 proves the defect-square identity and deduces Theorem A from the sign criterion. Section 8 proves Theorem B. Section 9 defines marked Kazhdan patterns and their compression-defect subgroups, proves the finite-normal obstruction criterion (Theorem 9.2) and the compression radical (Theorem 9.4). Section 10 proves Theorem D, constructs a sofic non-MF witness, and establishes the permanence failures. Section 11 proves the cyclic-base calibration. Section 12 explains the operator-norm boundary of the argument. Appendix A proves the MF equivalences.

4 NOTATION AND CORONA LEMMAS

All groups are discrete and countable. Property (T) is the textbook complex-unitary property. A C^* -homomorphism is unital only when this is stated. In particular, an MF embedding may be nonunital, as is customary for embedding a unital algebra as a C^* -subalgebra. If $e: A \rightarrow B$ is an injective, possibly nonunital $*$ -homomorphism between unital C^* -algebras, then $u \mapsto e(u) + (1 - e(1))$ is an injective homomorphism $\mathcal{U}(A) \rightarrow \mathcal{U}(B)$; this complement correction is used below. For a unital C^* -algebra A we write $\mathcal{U}(A)$ for its unitary group. On $M_r(\mathbb{C})$ we use the normalized trace tr_r , the operator norm $\|\cdot\|$, and the normalized Hilbert–Schmidt norm $\|x\|_2 = \text{tr}_r(x^*x)^{1/2}$; for coordinate sequences we write $a \sim_2 b$ when $\|a_n - b_n\|_2 \rightarrow 0$. We will use three elementary facts without further comment: $\|x\|_2 \leq \|x\|$; $|\text{tr}_r(x)| \leq \|x\|$; and $\|uxv\|_2 = \|x\|_2$ for unitaries u, v . For a nonempty finite set Y , write $M_Y(\mathbb{C}) = \mathbb{C}^{Y \times Y}$ for the corresponding indexed matrix algebra.

Given a sequence $(d_n)_{n \in \mathbb{N}}$ of positive integers, we write

$$\mathcal{Q}((d_n)_{n \in \mathbb{N}}) = \prod_{n \in \mathbb{N}}^{\ell^\infty} M_{d_n}(\mathbb{C}) / \bigoplus_{n \in \mathbb{N}}^{c_0} M_{d_n}(\mathbb{C}),$$

the quotient of the bounded C^* -product by the ideal of sequences with $\|x_n\| \rightarrow 0$. We call any such algebra a *norm matrix corona*. We also write

$$\mathcal{U}_{\text{cor}}((d_n)_{n \in \mathbb{N}}) = \prod_{n \in \mathbb{N}} \mathcal{U}(M_{d_n}(\mathbb{C})) / \{(u_n) : \|u_n - 1\| \rightarrow 0\}.$$

Write $q: \prod_{n \in \mathbb{N}}^{\ell^\infty} M_{d_n}(\mathbb{C}) \rightarrow \mathcal{Q}$ for the quotient map of a norm matrix corona.

The following lifting facts are standard perturbation theory; see Loring [Lo] for a systematic treatment.

Lemma 4.1 (lifting). *Every unitary $u \in \mathcal{Q}$ lifts to a sequence of unitaries.*

[formalized in Lean]

Proof. Lift u to an arbitrary bounded sequence (x_n) . Since $q((x_n))$ is unitary, both $\|x_n^*x_n - 1\| \rightarrow 0$ and $\|x_nx_n^* - 1\| \rightarrow 0$. In particular, $x_n^*x_n$ is invertible, and hence x_n is invertible, for all sufficiently large n . At those indices put $u_n = x_n(x_n^*x_n)^{-1/2}$. Then u_n is unitary, and, once $\|x_n^*x_n - 1\| \leq \frac{1}{2}$, continuous functional calculus gives the quantitative estimate

$$\|u_n - x_n\| \leq 2\|x_n\| \|x_n^*x_n - 1\|.$$

The sequence (x_n) is bounded, so the right-hand side tends to 0. Setting $u_n = 1$ at the finitely many remaining indices therefore gives a unitary sequence with $\|u_n - x_n\| \rightarrow 0$. $\square$

Lemma 4.2 (unitaries in the quotient). *For every sequence (d_n) , the map*

$$\kappa_{(d_n)}: \mathcal{U}_{\text{cor}}((d_n)) \longrightarrow \mathcal{U}(\mathcal{Q}), \quad [(u_n)] \longmapsto q((u_n)),$$

is a canonical group isomorphism. [formalized in Lean]

Proof. The map is well defined, and its kernel consists exactly of the unitary sequences satisfying $\|u_n - 1\| \rightarrow 0$, so it is injective. It is surjective by Lemma 4.1: every unitary in $\mathcal{Q}$ has a unitary lift (u_n) , whose class in (2) maps to it. $\square$

A *corona representation* of a group E is a homomorphism $E \rightarrow \mathcal{U}(\mathcal{Q})$. Lemma 4.2 canonically identifies it with a homomorphism into $\mathcal{U}_{\text{cor}}((d_n))$, which we call its coordinate model. The group E is *MF* if it admits an injective corona representation for a strictly increasing dimension sequence. By the dimension-amplification equivalence discussed in the introduction, allowing an arbitrary positive dimension sequence gives the same class of groups. A corona representation *detects* $g \in E$ if it does not send g to 1.

An *operator-norm asymptotic representation* of a group H is a sequence of maps $U_n: H \rightarrow \mathcal{U}(d_n)$, for some positive dimensions (d_n) , such that

$$\|U_n(g)U_n(h) - U_n(gh)\| \rightarrow 0 \quad (g, h \in H).$$

No condition is imposed at the identity: taking $g = h = 1$ gives $\|U_n(1) - 1\| \rightarrow 0$ automatically, since $U_n(1)$ is unitary. Coordinate unitary lifts of a corona representation of a countable group form exactly such a sequence.

Fix a set-theoretic universe $\mathfrak{U}$. For a $\mathfrak{U}$ -small group H , define $C_{\text{max}, \mathfrak{U}}^*(H)$ to be the closed $*$ -subalgebra generated by the diagonal copy of H in the bounded product of all its nontrivial unitary representations on $\mathfrak{U}$ -small unital C^* -algebras. This algebra lives in the next universe. We suppress the subscript $\mathfrak{U}$ below and write u_h for the canonical unitary associated with $h \in H$.

Proposition 4.3 (universe-relative maximal group algebra). *The canonical map $h \mapsto u_h$ is injective. For every $\mathfrak{U}$ -small unital C^* -algebra B and every homomorphism $\rho: H \rightarrow \mathcal{U}(B)$, there is a unique unital $*$ -homomorphism $C_{\text{max}, \mathfrak{U}}^*(H) \rightarrow B$ mapping u_h to $\rho(h)$ for every $h \in H$. [formalized in Lean]*

For a nontrivial target, projection to its coordinate gives the extension; for a trivial target, the map is unique. Density of the generated $*$ -subalgebra gives uniqueness, while the left-regular coordinate proves injectivity.

5 THE LITERAL GROUP AND ITS KAZHDAN SOURCE

We work throughout with the groups defined by the relators below. The proof of property (T) identifies the base with a standard affine matrix group; every later relation involving its image in E is used directly from the displayed presentation. First define the *rotation group*

$$(7) \quad \mathcal{R} = \left\langle x, y, z \mid \begin{array}{l} x^3 = y^3 = z^2 = (xz)^3 = (yz)^3 = 1, \\ (x^{-1}zxy)^2 = (y^{-1}zyx)^2 = (xy)^6 = 1 \end{array} \right\rangle,$$

and the *literal base*

(8)

$$\mathcal{B} = \left\langle v_1, v_2, v_3, x, y, z \left| \begin{array}{l} \text{the eight relations in (7),} \\ [v_1, v_2] = [v_1, v_3] = [v_2, v_3] = 1, \\ xv_1x^{-1} = v_3, \quad xv_2x^{-1} = v_1, \quad xv_3x^{-1} = v_2, \\ yv_1y^{-1} = v_1, \quad yv_2y^{-1} = v_2^{-1}v_3, \quad yv_3y^{-1} = v_1v_2^{-1}, \\ zv_1z^{-1} = v_2v_3^{-1}, \quad zv_2z^{-1} = v_1v_3^{-1}, \quad zv_3z^{-1} = v_3^{-1} \end{array} \right. \right\rangle.$$

Write $\iota: \mathcal{B} \rightarrow E$ for the homomorphism induced by the first six generators of the presentation below. This map is not assumed to be injective.

Definition 5.1. Use the six literal base generators and the relations displayed in (8). Define

$$(9) \quad E = \left\langle v_1, v_2, v_3, x, y, z, t, c \left| \begin{array}{l} \text{all relations in (8),} \\ tv_it^{-1} = v_i^2 \quad (1 \leq i \leq 3), \\ txt^{-1} = x, \quad tyt^{-1} = y, \quad tzt^{-1} = z, \\ c^2 = 1, \\ [c, g] = 1 \quad (g \in \{v_1, v_2, v_3, x, y, z\}), \\ [w, g] = 1 \quad (g \in \{v_1, v_2, v_3, x, y, z, t, c\}) \end{array} \right. \right\rangle,$$

where w abbreviates the word $[tct^{-1}, v_1(tct^{-1})v_1^{-1}]$. This is an explicit finite presentation with eight generators and forty-one relators: the twenty base relators, six stable-letter relators, c^2 , six lamp relators, and eight centrality relators. Its defining relations make w central, and centrality together with $c^2 = 1$ implies $w^2 = 1$ by (5); the relations on the six base generators also give

$$t\iota(\mathcal{B})t^{-1} \subseteq \iota(\mathcal{B}), \quad [c, \iota(\mathcal{B})] = 1.$$

[formalized in Lean]

Six generators suffice. The group E is generated by v_1, x, y, z, t, c ; in particular its group rank is at most six. [formalized in Lean] There is also a Tietze-equivalent presentation on these six generators with thirty-two relators. In (9), eliminate v_3 and v_2 by the Tietze substitutions

$$v_3 = xv_1x^{-1}, \quad v_2 = x^2v_1x^{-2}.$$

Delete the two relations used as definitions. After substitution, the remaining x -action relation follows from $x^3 = 1$. The two stable-letter relations for v_2, v_3 follow from the one for v_1 and $[t, x] = 1$; the two lamp relations and two centrality relations for v_2, v_3 similarly follow from those for v_1 and x . These six redundant relators may therefore be deleted. Starting from forty-one relators, the two Tietze definitions, the remaining x -action relation, and those six consequences leave thirty-two, on the generators v_1, x, y, z, t, c .

Proposition 6.3 below proves that $w \neq 1$. Figure 1 isolates the geometry used later in the analytic argument: $d = tct^{-1}$ centralizes the compressed

copy, not necessarily all of $\iota(\mathcal{B})$, and the marked commutator measures precisely that failure after conjugating d by $\iota(v_1)$.

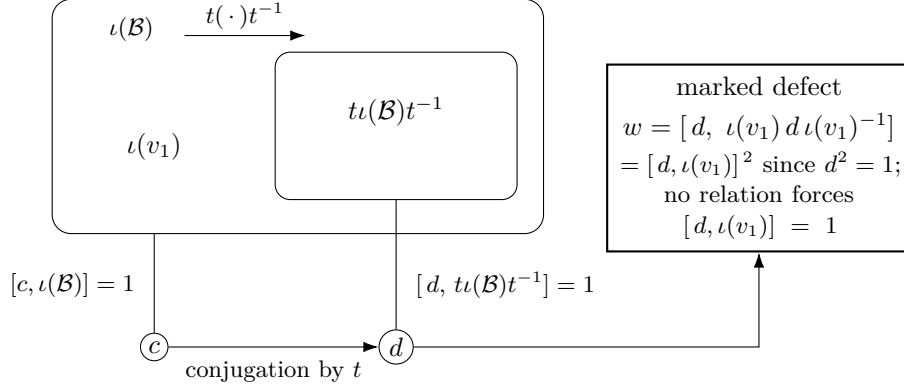


Figure 1: The marked-compression pattern. Conjugation by t carries the image of the literal base into itself. It sends c to $d = tct^{-1}$: the relations force c to commute with all of $\iota(\mathcal{B})$ and force d to commute with the compressed copy, but do not require d to commute with $\iota(v_1)$. The marked word w records that commutation defect. Only the one-sided inclusion is used by the analytic criterion; the separate Clifford witness proves that the canonical base map in this explicit group is injective.

In particular the compression argument needs only the one-sided inclusion and centralizer relations shown in Figure 1; it never uses injectivity or properness of the base map. Injectivity for the constructed group is established independently by the Clifford realization.

5.1 Property (T) of the base

Proposition 5.2. *The twenty-relator group $\mathcal{B}$ has property (T), in both the real-orthogonal and complex-unitary formulations.* [formalized in Lean]

Proof. The eight relations in (7) are the Conder–Robertson–Williams presentation of $\mathrm{SL}_3(\mathbb{Z})$ [CRW, Theorem 2]. The matrix-labelled form for x, y, z displayed in Lemma 6.2 is also recorded in [CLV]. The remaining relations say that v_1, v_2, v_3 commute and that x, y, z act on them by the columns of those three matrices. This does more than define a quotient. The map from the presentation to $\mathbb{Z}^3 \rtimes \mathrm{SL}_3(\mathbb{Z})$ sends v_i to $(e_i, 1)$ and each rotation generator to its labelled matrix. In the other direction, send (n_1, n_2, n_3, A) to

$$v_1^{n_1} v_2^{n_2} v_3^{n_3} \overline{A},$$

where $A \mapsto \overline{A}$ is the inverse of the isomorphism from the eight-relator rotation group to $\mathrm{SL}_3(\mathbb{Z})$. The nine conjugation relations give covariance first for

x, y, z , hence for every A ; so this second map is a homomorphism. The two maps fix the six displayed generators and are inverse.

Property (T) of $\mathbb{Z}^n \rtimes \mathrm{SL}_n(\mathbb{Z})$ for $n \geq 3$ is classical [BHV, Example 1.7.4(i)]. Realification and complexification identify the real and complex formulations. $\square$

6 THE WITNESS: $w \neq 1$

Clifford signs, shifts, and HNN doubling have appeared together before in approximate-representation theory, notably in Slofstra’s hyperlinear-profile construction [Slo18, Section 2]. The construction below uses the Clifford lamp only as an explicit algebraic witness. It uses the displayed quotient of the literal base and is independent of the semantic identification used above to prove property (T).

Construction 6.1 (Clifford lamp groups). For a set X , use the real Clifford-algebra convention generated by $(c_x)_{x \in X}$ with $c_x^2 = 1$ and $c_x c_y = -c_y c_x$ for $x \neq y$, and let $\mathrm{ClLamp}(X)$ be the subgroup of units generated by -1 and the c_x . Write $\zeta = -1$. In this concrete group,

$$\zeta^2 = c_x^2 = 1, \quad c_x c_y = \zeta c_y c_x \quad (x \neq y).$$

The sign ζ is nontrivial. Every permutation of X acts on this group by $c_x \mapsto c_{\sigma(x)}$ and fixes ζ . [formalized in Lean]

Lemma 6.2 (linear model). *For $M \in \mathrm{GL}_3(\mathbb{Q})$ and $u \in \mathbb{Q}^3$, write*

$$A(M, u) = \begin{pmatrix} M & u \\ 0 & 1 \end{pmatrix}.$$

Assign $v_i \mapsto A(I_3, e_i)$ and

$$\begin{aligned} x &\mapsto A\left(\begin{pmatrix} 0 & 1 & 0 \\ 0 & 0 & 1 \\ 1 & 0 & 0 \end{pmatrix}, 0\right), & y &\mapsto A\left(\begin{pmatrix} 1 & 0 & 1 \\ 0 & -1 & -1 \\ 0 & 1 & 0 \end{pmatrix}, 0\right), \\ z &\mapsto A\left(\begin{pmatrix} 0 & 1 & 0 \\ 1 & 0 & 0 \\ -1 & -1 & -1 \end{pmatrix}, 0\right). \end{aligned}$$

Let $\bar{\Gamma} \leq \mathrm{GL}_4(\mathbb{Q})$ be the subgroup generated by these six matrices, and put $D = \mathrm{diag}(2, 2, 2, 1)$. Direct matrix computation proves that the six matrices satisfy all twenty relators of $\mathcal{B}$ and that

$$\bar{\alpha}(u) = DuD^{-1}$$

is an injective endomorphism of $\bar{\Gamma}$ which squares the three translation generators and fixes x, y, z . Moreover the matrix assigned to v_1 does not lie in $\mathrm{range}(\bar{\alpha})$. [formalized in Lean]

Proof. The twenty relator checks reduce to sixteen rational identities for each matrix equation. Conjugation by D gives the six stable-letter equations and is injective because it is conjugation by an invertible matrix. Every

displayed generator and its explicitly computed inverse has integral entries; equivalently, all six generators lie in $\mathrm{GL}_4(\mathbb{Z})$. Hence $\bar{\Gamma} \leq \mathrm{GL}_4(\mathbb{Z})$. However $D^{-1}\bar{v}_1 D$ has entry $1/2$ in position $(1, 4)$, so it is not in $\bar{\Gamma}$. This proves the last assertion. $\square$

Form the mapping telescope of $\bar{\alpha}$, extend it by its shift τ , and call the resulting group V . Let $j: \bar{\Gamma} \hookrightarrow V$ be its level-zero map and put $X = V/j(\bar{\Gamma})$, with root $o = j(\bar{\Gamma})$. The final assertion of Lemma 6.2 is exactly the statement that

$$\tau o \neq j(\bar{v}_1)\tau o.$$

Thus the Clifford generators at these two sites anticommute.

Proposition 6.3. *$w \neq 1$ in E .* [formalized in Lean]

Proof. Form $W := \mathrm{CLamp}(X) \rtimes V$ as in Construction 6.1. Define a map on the generators of (9) by

$$\begin{aligned} g \mapsto j(\bar{g}) \in V \quad (g \in \{v_1, v_2, v_3, x, y, z\}), \\ t \mapsto \tau, \quad c \mapsto c_o. \end{aligned}$$

The exact checks in Lemma 6.2 give the twenty base and six stable-letter relations. The level-zero subgroup fixes o , so c_o commutes with every base generator, and $c_o^2 = 1$. Under this assignment,

$$tct^{-1} \mapsto c_{\tau o}, \quad v_1(tct^{-1})v_1^{-1} \mapsto c_{j(\bar{v}_1)\tau o},$$

and the two sites are distinct by Lemma 6.2, so

$$w \mapsto [c_{\tau o}, c_{j(\bar{v}_1)\tau o}] = -1 = \zeta.$$

Since ζ is central in W , the remaining relations $[w, g] = 1$ for $g \in \{v_1, v_2, v_3, x, y, z, t, c\}$ are also satisfied. Hence the assignment extends to a group homomorphism $E \rightarrow W$ sending w to $\zeta \neq 1$, and therefore $w \neq 1$ in E . $\square$

Scope of the witness. The target uses the infinite group $\mathrm{CLamp}(X)$ when X is infinite, but each group element involves only finitely many Clifford sites; the remaining data are rational matrices. No normal-form theorem for an HNN extension enters: the mapping telescope supplies the required group and the range characterization separates the two sites.

7 THE DEFECT SQUARE AND THE PROOF OF THEOREM A

Lemma 7.1 (the marked word is a defect square). *Let H_1 be a group and $d, a_1 \in H_1$ with $d^2 = 1$. Then*

$$[d, a_1 d a_1^{-1}] = [d, a_1]^2.$$

[formalized in Lean]

Proof. Put $b = a_1 d a_1^{-1}$, so $b^2 = a_1 d^2 a_1^{-1} = 1$; thus $b^{-1} = b$ and $d^{-1} = d$. Then $[d, a_1] = d a_1 d^{-1} a_1^{-1} = d(a_1 d a_1^{-1}) = db$, and

$$[d, a_1]^2 = (db)^2 = db db = d b d^{-1} b^{-1} = [d, b]. \quad \square$$

Proof of Theorem A. Part (1) is Proposition 6.3. For part (2), let $\Theta: E \rightarrow \mathcal{U}_{\text{cor}}((d_n))$ be given and pass to the corona representation $\kappa_{(d_n)} \circ \Theta: E \rightarrow \mathcal{U}(\mathcal{Q})$ of Lemma 4.2. Apply the central-sign criterion (Theorem 2.2) with $\Gamma = \mathcal{B}$, the canonical homomorphism ι , the elements $t, c \in E$, and $a = v_1$. Its hypotheses are exactly the displayed relators: Proposition 5.2 gives property (T) of $\mathcal{B}$; the six stable-letter relators give $t\iota(\mathcal{B})t^{-1} \subseteq \iota(\mathcal{B})$; and the six lamp relators give $[c, \iota(\mathcal{B})] = 1$. No injectivity of ι is required. In E we have $d^2 = (tgt^{-1})^2 = tc^2t^{-1} = 1$, so Lemma 7.1 with $a_1 = \iota(v_1)$ identifies the marked word as the square of the compression defect $u = [d, \iota(v_1)]$:

$$w = [d, \iota(v_1) d \iota(v_1)^{-1}] = [d, \iota(v_1)]^2 = u^2.$$

Centrality of w is a defining relator; together with $c^2 = 1$ it forces $w^2 = 1$ by (5); and $w \neq 1$ by part (1). The criterion therefore kills w in every corona representation of E . Since $\kappa_{(d_n)}$ is injective, $\Theta(w) = 1$. This proves part (2).

For the final assertions of Theorem A: an MF embedding of E would be an injective corona representation, which is impossible because every corona representation sends the nontrivial element w to 1. If $C_{\text{red}}^*(E)$ were an MF algebra, an injective, possibly nonunital $*$ -homomorphism $e: C_{\text{red}}^*(E) \rightarrow \mathcal{Q}$ would give the injective unitary homomorphism $u \mapsto e(u) + (1 - e(1))$. Composing it with the canonical map $E \rightarrow \mathcal{U}(C_{\text{red}}^*(E))$, and then with $\kappa_{(d_n)}^{-1}$, would exhibit an injective corona representation of E : the map $g \mapsto \lambda_g$ is injective. The canonical map $E \rightarrow \mathcal{U}(C_{\text{max}}^*(E))$ is injective as well, because the left regular representation factors through $C_{\text{max}}^*(E)$ and sends u_g to λ_g . Thus an MF embedding of $C_{\text{max}}^*(E)$ would again produce an injective corona representation of E after the same $\kappa_{(d_n)}^{-1}$ conversion. $\square$

The marked radical element. The proof shows more than non-injectivity of each individual Θ : the fixed element w lies in the kernel of *every* corona representation of E , so every corona representation factors through $E/\langle w \rangle$ (note $\langle w \rangle = \{1, w\}$ is central, hence normal). In the language of approximation radicals, w is a nontrivial element of the “MF radical” of E . This terminology is meant in analogy with Slofstra’s earlier quotients G^{fin} and G^{fa} , obtained by killing elements invisible to exact and approximate finite-dimensional representations, respectively [Slo17, Definitions 2.5–2.7]. By Theorem 9.2 the same holds in every countable group with a marked Kazhdan pattern: every finite normal subgroup of the compression-defect subgroup lies in the MF radical. Section 10 develops the radical systematically; we do not know whether $E/\langle w \rangle$ is MF, i.e. whether the MF radical of E is exactly $\{1, w\}$. No density hypothesis. No lower bound on the corner ranks r_n , or on their density in d_n , is used anywhere: the central-corner reduction preceding Theorem 2.2 equips each nonzero corner block with its own normalized trace. Thus all subsequent Hilbert–Schmidt estimates are relative to that block. This is what makes the operator-norm setting insensitive to small relative ranks, which block the same argument in Hilbert–Schmidt metrics (Section 12).

8 THE FINITE-DIMENSIONAL OBSTRUCTION

We prove Theorem B. Everything happens inside the finite-dimensional algebra $\text{End}_k(V)$.

Proof of Theorem B. Let $\pi: H \rightarrow \text{GL}(V)$ be a homomorphism and let

$$C = \{x \in \text{End}_k(V) : \pi(\gamma)x = x\pi(\gamma) \text{ for all } \gamma \in \Gamma\}$$

be the commutant of $\pi(\Gamma)$, a linear subspace of $\text{End}_k(V)$. Let $u = \pi(t)$ and consider the linear automorphism $\Phi(x) = uxu^{-1}$ of $\text{End}_k(V)$.

We claim $C \subseteq \Phi(C)$. Let $x \in C$ and set $y = u^{-1}xu$, so that $x = \Phi(y)$. For $\gamma \in \Gamma$ we have $t\gamma t^{-1} \in \Gamma$, hence $\pi(t\gamma t^{-1})$ commutes with x , and therefore

$$\pi(\gamma)y = u^{-1}\pi(t\gamma t^{-1})xu = u^{-1}x\pi(t\gamma t^{-1})u = y\pi(\gamma).$$

Thus $y \in C$, proving the claim. Since Φ is a linear isomorphism, $\dim_k \Phi(C) = \dim_k C < \infty$, and the inclusion $C \subseteq \Phi(C)$ forces

$$(10) \quad C = \Phi(C) = uCu^{-1}.$$

Now $\pi(c) \in C$ because c centralizes Γ . By (10), $\pi(tct^{-1}) = u\pi(c)u^{-1} \in C$. Since $a \in \Gamma$, the element $\pi(tct^{-1})$ commutes with $\pi(a)$, so $\pi(a(tct^{-1})a^{-1}) = \pi(tct^{-1})$, and therefore

$$\pi([tct^{-1}, a(tct^{-1})a^{-1}]) = [\pi(tct^{-1}), \pi(tct^{-1})] = 1. \quad \square$$

The same calculation proves the final, subgroup-valued assertion of Theorem B. The elements of H whose conjugation action preserves C in both directions form a subgroup. The argument above puts every one-sided compressor in that subgroup, and therefore puts all of $G_{\text{comp}}(\Gamma)$ in it. Thus, for $g \in G_{\text{comp}}(\Gamma)$ and $z \in C_H(\Gamma)$, the operator $\pi(gzg^{-1})$ still belongs to C and commutes with every $\pi(\ell)$, $\ell \in \Gamma$. Hence π kills all the generators in (6), and normality of its kernel kills their normal closure.

Corollary 8.1. *The group E of Definition 5.1 admits no injective homomorphism into $\text{GL}(V)$ for any finite-dimensional vector space V over any field. More strongly, every finite-dimensional linear representation maps w to the identity, and every homomorphism to a finite group maps w to the identity.* [formalized in Lean]

Proof. Apply Theorem B with $H = E$, the image of $\mathcal{B}$, and the elements t, c, v_1 ; the hypotheses hold by the defining relations (9). Every finite-dimensional representation kills w , and $w \neq 1$ by Proposition 6.3. A finite target embeds into a finite symmetric group and hence into a finite-dimensional general linear group via permutation matrices, so it also maps w to the identity. $\square$

Why the corona argument is different. The proof of Theorem B used only that a finite-dimensional subspace cannot be properly contained in an isomorphic image of itself. An MF model is only asymptotically multiplicative, so its coordinate fixed spaces are not literal invariant subspaces. Operator-norm control makes the adjoint actions into an exact representation on the Hilbert ultraproduct. Property (T) then supplies its fixed-space projection, and finiteness of the norm ultraproduct turns the one-sided inclusion into equality.

9 KAZHDAN TRANSPORT AND FINITE-NORMAL CANCELLATION

Theorem A is already proved. This section establishes the general finite-normal obstruction behind it, using the transport theorem above and an operator-norm corner reduction. We fix the data of the criterion.

Definition 9.1 (marked Kazhdan pattern). Let H be a countable group. A *marked Kazhdan pattern* in H is a tuple (Λ, ι, t, c) , where Λ is a countable group with property (T), $\iota: \Lambda \rightarrow H$ is a group homomorphism — *not* assumed injective — and $t, c \in H$, subject to

- (M1) $t \iota(\lambda) t^{-1} \in \iota(\Lambda)$ for every $\lambda \in \Lambda$;
- (M2) $c \iota(\lambda) = \iota(\lambda) c$ for every $\lambda \in \Lambda$.

Write $d := tct^{-1}$. The *compression-defect subgroup* of the pattern is the normal closure

$$N_{\text{comp}} = \langle\langle [d, \iota(\lambda)] : \lambda \in \Lambda \rangle\rangle_H \trianglelefteq H.$$

[formalized in Lean]

Theorem 9.2 (finite-normal obstruction criterion). *Let H be a countable group with a marked Kazhdan pattern (Λ, ι, t, c) , and let $F \trianglelefteq H$ be a finite normal subgroup with $F \subseteq N_{\text{comp}}$. Then every corona representation $\Theta: H \rightarrow \mathcal{U}(\mathcal{Q})$ satisfies $\Theta(f) = 1$ for all $f \in F$.* [formalized in Lean]

Proof. Suppose that a corona representation Θ is nontrivial on F . Form the Reynolds projection directly in the quotient,

$$p = \frac{1}{|F|} \sum_{f \in F} \Theta(f), \quad q = 1 - p.$$

The group average satisfies $p^* = p$, because F is closed under inversion, and $p^2 = p$, because left translation by each $\Theta(f_0)$ permutes the summands, so that $\Theta(f_0)p = p$; averaging over $f_0 \in F$ gives idempotence, and the same identities show p projects onto the vectors fixed by $\Theta(F)$. Normality of F makes p central relative to $\Theta(H)$. If $q = 0$, then $p = 1$ and $\Theta(f)p = p$ for every $f \in F$, so $\Theta|_F$ is trivial; hence $q \neq 0$. Since q commutes with $\Theta(H)$, the formula

$$\Theta_q(g) = q\Theta(g)q$$

defines a homomorphism $H \rightarrow \mathcal{U}(q\mathcal{Q}q)$, with corner unit q . There

$$(*) \quad \sum_{f \in F} \Theta_q(f) = q \left(\sum_{f \in F} \Theta(f) \right) q = |F|qpq = 0$$

exactly.

Choose a sequence of coordinate projections (q_n) representing q ; this is obtained by applying a spectral cut to a self-adjoint lift of q . If $J = \{n : q_n \neq 0\}$, then J is infinite because $q \neq 0$. Restriction to J , followed by a relabeling of J by $\mathbb{N}$, identifies the corner with

$$\begin{aligned} q\mathcal{Q}q &\cong \prod_{n \in \mathbb{N}} q_n M_{d_n}(\mathbb{C}) q_n / \bigoplus_{n \in \mathbb{N}} q_n M_{d_n}(\mathbb{C}) q_n, \\ &\cong \prod_{n \in \mathbb{N}} M_{r_n}(\mathbb{C}) / \bigoplus_{n \in \mathbb{N}} M_{r_n}(\mathbb{C}), \quad r_n = \text{rank } q_n > 0. \end{aligned}$$

Thus zero-rank coordinates are discarded, rather than treated as matrix coordinates of size zero. Since H is countable, choose coordinate lifts of all the elements $\Theta_q(g)$. For each fixed g , its two unitary defects tend to zero; on a g -dependent cofinite tail polar correction gives $U_{g,n} \in \mathcal{U}(r_n)$, and at the finitely many remaining indices choose an arbitrary unitary. The homomorphism identity for Θ_q then makes these lifts asymptotically multiplicative. Put

$$K_2 = \{g \in H : \|U_{g,n} - 1\|_2 \rightarrow 0\}.$$

Unitary invariance and asymptotic multiplicativity make $K_2 \trianglelefteq H$. Since c centralizes $\iota(\Lambda)$, its lifts belong to the asymptotic commutant of $\iota(\Lambda)$. Applying Theorem 2.1 to $x_n = U_{c,n}$ shows that the lifts of $d = tct^{-1}$ do as well, and therefore

$$[d, \iota(\lambda)] \in K_2 \quad (\lambda \in \Lambda).$$

Hence $N_{\text{comp}} \subseteq K_2$, and therefore $F \subseteq K_2$. Because F is finite,

$$\sum_{f \in F} U_{f,n} \rightarrow |F|1 \quad \text{in normalized Hilbert-Schmidt norm.}$$

On the other hand, the exact quotient identity $(*)$ for Θ_q says that the same sum converges to 0 in operator norm, hence also in normalized Hilbert-Schmidt norm. This contradiction proves the theorem. $\square$

Theorem A(2), proved in Section 7 from the sign criterion, is also the instance $H = E$, $\Lambda = \mathcal{B}$, ι the canonical homomorphism, and $F = \{1, w\}$ of Theorem 9.2; the membership $w \in N_{\text{comp}}$ is the identity $w = [d, \iota(v_1)]^2$ of Lemma 7.1. The ultraproduct proof of Theorem 2.1 is the shortest form of the argument and already gives the ordinary sequential convergence needed above.

A uniform finite obstruction. There are a number $\delta > 0$ and a finite set $F_0 \subset E$ such that, in every matrix dimension, any unitary-valued map ϕ satisfying

$$\|\phi(gh) - \phi(g)\phi(h)\| \leq \delta \quad (g, h \in F_0)$$

also satisfies $\|\phi(w) - 1\| < 1$. [formalized in Lean] Thus the non-MF conclusion has a finite, dimension-free formulation that does not mention an ultrafilter. The compactness proof does not compute δ or F_0 ; obtaining an effective modulus directly from the rational spectral certificate remains a sharper quantitative problem.

9.1 The compression radical The transport estimate localizes at a single compressor t , but nothing in it is specific to t . Recall from (6) the subgroup $G_{\text{comp}}(L)$ generated by all one-sided compressors of a subgroup $L \leq H$ and the intrinsic compression–centralizer defect $\mathfrak{D}(H, L)$.

Corollary 9.3 (transport along all compressors). *Let (r_n) and $V_{g,n} \in \mathcal{U}(r_n)$ be an operator-norm asymptotic representation of H , let Λ have property (T), let $\iota: \Lambda \rightarrow H$ be a homomorphism, and put $L = \iota(\Lambda)$. Suppose that $(x_n \in M_{r_n}(\mathbb{C}))$ is uniformly bounded in operator norm and belongs to the asymptotic commutant of L :*

$$\|x_n - V_{\iota(\lambda),n} x_n V_{\iota(\lambda),n}^*\|_2 \longrightarrow 0 \quad (\lambda \in \Lambda).$$

Then every $g \in G_{\text{comp}}(L)$ acts in both directions on that asymptotic commutant. Explicitly, both

$$V_{g,n} x_n V_{g,n}^* \quad \text{and} \quad V_{g,n}^* x_n V_{g,n}$$

satisfy the preceding convergence for every $\lambda \in \Lambda$. [formalized in Lean]

Proof. For a one-sided compressor s , Theorem 2.1 gives forward transport. In that theorem’s proof the Kazhdan projection satisfies $P = VPV^*$, so both V and V^* preserve its range; the identical subsequence argument gives reverse transport. The elements acting in both directions form a subgroup of H , and hence contain the subgroup generated by all one-sided compressors, namely $G_{\text{comp}}(L)$. $\square$

Theorem 9.4 (compression radical). *Let H and Γ be countable groups, let Γ have property (T), let $\iota: \Gamma \rightarrow H$ be a homomorphism, and put $L = \iota(\Gamma)$. If $F \trianglelefteq H$ is finite and $F \leq \mathfrak{D}(H, L)$, then every homomorphism from H to every norm matrix corona kills F .* [formalized in Lean]

Proof. Suppose a corona representation is nontrivial on F . Its complementary Reynolds corner, constructed in the proof of Theorem 9.2, has positive coordinate ranks and satisfies $\sum_{f \in F} U_{f,n} \rightarrow 0$ in operator norm. Put $K_2 = \{h : \|U_{h,n} - 1\|_2 \rightarrow 0\}$; this is a normal subgroup of H . If $z \in C_H(L)$, then $(U_{z,n})$ lies in the asymptotic commutant, and Corollary 9.3 puts $(U_{gzg^{-1},n})$ there for every $g \in G_{\text{comp}}(L)$. Thus every displayed generator of $\mathfrak{D}(H, L)$ belongs to K_2 , so $F \leq K_2$. Finiteness of F now gives

$\sum_{f \in F} U_{f,n} \rightarrow |F|1$ in normalized Hilbert–Schmidt norm, contradicting its operator-norm convergence to zero. $\square$

10 CONSEQUENCES

We record the universal MF radical, the reduced-group- C^* consequence, a sofic non-MF detector, and failures of quotient and extension permanence. They all come from the same marked element.

10.1 The MF radical

Definition 10.1. For a countable group G_1 , the *MF radical* is

$$\text{Rad}_{\text{MF}}(G_1) = \bigcap \{ \ker \Theta : \Theta \text{ a corona representation of } G_1 \},$$

a normal subgroup of G_1 . This is the operator-norm analogue of the invisible subgroups of [Slo17, Definitions 2.5–2.7] and of the metric-ultraproduct approximation framework of [NST]. [formalized in Lean]

Lemma 10.2 (portability). *For every homomorphism $\varphi: G_1 \rightarrow G_2$ of countable groups,*

$$\varphi(\text{Rad}_{\text{MF}}(G_1)) \subseteq \text{Rad}_{\text{MF}}(G_2) :$$

the MF radical is functorial. In particular, if $\varphi: E \rightarrow G_2$ satisfies $\varphi(w) \neq 1$, then G_2 is not MF. [formalized in Lean]

Proof. If $x \in \text{Rad}_{\text{MF}}(G_1)$ and Θ is a corona representation of G_2 , then $\Theta \circ \varphi$ is a corona representation of G_1 , so $\Theta(\varphi(x)) = 1$. For the second statement: $w \in \text{Rad}_{\text{MF}}(E)$ by Theorem A, so $1 \neq \varphi(w) \in \text{Rad}_{\text{MF}}(G_2)$, and an injective corona representation of G_2 would kill $\varphi(w)$, a contradiction. $\square$

Proposition 10.3 (the universal MF quotient). *Let G_1 be a countable group and $R = \text{Rad}_{\text{MF}}(G_1)$.*

- (1) *R is the kernel of a single corona representation of G_1 .*
- (2) *G_1/R is MF.*
- (3) *Every homomorphism from G_1 to an MF group factors through G_1/R .*

In particular G_1 is MF if and only if $R = \{1\}$. [formalized in Lean]

The statement is presumably folklore once the radical is defined; the proof is included for completeness, with no claim of novelty.

Proof. (3) If $\varphi: G_1 \rightarrow M$ with M MF and $j: M \rightarrow \text{U}_{\text{cor}}((d_n))$ is an injective corona representation, then $j \circ \varphi$ is a corona representation of G_1 , so $j(\varphi(R)) = 1$ and, by injectivity of j , $\varphi(R) = 1$.

(1) and (2). Work on $Q = G_1/R$ from the outset. If $1 \neq q \in Q$ and $g \in G_1$ represents q , then $g \notin R$. Hence some corona representation of G_1 detects g . Every corona representation kills R by definition, so this representation descends to one of Q that detects q . Thus the intersection of the kernels of all corona representations of the countable group Q is trivial.

Enumerate the nonidentity elements of Q and choose a detecting corona representation for each. Diagonalize these local models directly: at stage k ,

impose multiplicativity within $1/k$ on the first k group elements in the first k representations and retain a fixed positive separation for each of the first k marked elements. This gives one faithful representation of Q in a norm matrix corona and proves (2). Composing it with $G_1 \rightarrow Q$ gives a single corona representation of G_1 with kernel exactly R , proving (1). For the final equivalence: if G_1 is MF, an injective corona representation forces $R = \{1\}$; if $R = \{1\}$, then (2) says $G_1 = G_1/R$ is MF. $\square$

Corollary 10.4 (exact radical from a candidate quotient). *Let $N \trianglelefteq G_1$ satisfy $N \leq \text{Rad}_{\text{MF}}(G_1)$. Every corona representation of G_1 factors uniquely through G_1/N . If in addition G_1/N is MF, then*

$$\text{Rad}_{\text{MF}}(G_1) = N.$$

[formalized in Lean]

Together with Proposition 10.3, this says that proving a concrete defect subgroup invisible and its quotient MF computes both the entire MF radical and the universal MF quotient.

Proof. The containment $N \leq \ker \Theta$ gives the unique quotient factorization for every corona representation Θ . For the reverse containment in the displayed equality, compose the quotient map $G_1 \rightarrow G_1/N$ with an injective corona representation of G_1/N : its kernel is exactly N , while the MF radical lies in the kernel of every corona representation. $\square$

Corollary 10.5. *Let A be a unital C^* -algebra admitting an injective, possibly nonunital, $*$ -homomorphism into a norm matrix corona. Then the group E admits no injective homomorphism into $\mathcal{U}(A)$.* [formalized in Lean]

Proof. Let $j: A \rightarrow Q$ be the possibly nonunital inclusion into the ambient corona and let $\phi: E \rightarrow \mathcal{U}(A)$. Complement correction gives

$$\hat{j}(u) = j(u) + 1 - j(1_A) \in \mathcal{U}(Q).$$

This is an injective homomorphism on $\mathcal{U}(A)$, so $\hat{j} \circ \phi$ is a corona representation of E . The universal kernel theorem sends w to the identity there; injectivity of $\hat{j}$ gives $\phi(w) = 1$. Proposition 6.3 has $w \neq 1$, so ϕ cannot be injective. $\square$

10.2 A finite universal Horn obstruction Theorem A can be read as one first-order fact about all MF groups at once. Write R for the forty-one relators of (9), regarded as words in eight variables, and w for the marked word in those variables.

Proposition 10.6 (finite quasi-identity). *Every MF group G satisfies the finite universal Horn sentence*

$$\forall x_1, \dots, x_8: \bigwedge_{r \in R} r(x_1, \dots, x_8) = 1 \implies w(x_1, \dots, x_8) = 1,$$

while the canonical generating tuple of E satisfies every relator in R and has $w \neq 1$. [formalized in Lean]

Proof. A tuple satisfying the relators induces a homomorphism $E \rightarrow G$ sending the marked word of E to $w(x_1, \dots, x_8)$. If G is MF, then Lemma 10.2 and Theorem A make that image trivial. The canonical tuple of E satisfies R by definition, and its marked word is nontrivial by Theorem A(1). $\square$

Corollary 10.7 (a clopen non-MF cylinder). *In the space of eight-generator marked groups — quotients of the free group F_8 , topologized so that a basic clopen set fixes the truth of finitely many equations among words in the generators — the marked groups satisfying all relators of R and $w \neq 1$ form a nonempty clopen set consisting entirely of non-MF groups.* [formalized in Lean]

Proof. Both conditions constrain finitely many values of the marked multiplication, so the set is clopen; it contains the marked group E by Theorem A(1), and Proposition 10.6 excludes every MF point. $\square$

Thus the obstruction of Theorem A is finite, local, and stable under perturbation in marked-group space.

10.3 Permanence and its failure

Lemma 10.8 (subgroups). *Every subgroup of an MF group is MF.* [formalized in Lean]

Proof. Restrict an injective corona representation to the subgroup: injectivity and the homomorphism law are preserved, and the dimension normalization of Proposition 1.1 is unaffected. $\square$

Lemma 10.9 (residually finite groups). *Every countable residually finite group is MF.* [formalized in Lean]

Proof. Choose a sequence of finite quotients separating the nonidentity elements and intersect kernels, so that the family is descending. At coordinate n take the left regular representation of the n th quotient. Every pair of group elements is represented exactly multiplicatively at every coordinate, since each coordinate map is a genuine homomorphism. A nonidentity element g eventually survives to the n th quotient, where left translation by it is a fixed-point-free permutation $\pi_n(g)$; a fixed-point-free permutation matrix has an eigenvalue at angle at least $2\pi/3$ from 1, so $\|\pi_n(g) - 1\| \geq \sqrt{3}$. The induced map to the corona is therefore an injective homomorphism. $\square$

Lemma 10.10 (locally finite groups). *Every countable locally finite group is MF.* [formalized in Lean]

Proof. A countable locally finite group is the increasing union of a chain of finite subgroups $F_1 \leq F_2 \leq \dots$. At coordinate n take the left regular representation of F_n , extended by the identity outside F_n . Every pair of elements is eventually multiplied exactly, and a nonidentity element

eventually acts by left translation on some F_n containing it — a fixed-point-free permutation — so the separation $\|\pi_n(g) - 1\| \geq \sqrt{3}$ from the proof of Lemma 10.9 applies verbatim. $\square$

Corollary 10.11 (quotients). *MF groups are not closed under quotients: the free group F_8 is MF, and the literal group E is its quotient but is not MF.* [formalized in Lean]

Proof. Map the eight free generators onto the eight displayed generators of E . The resulting homomorphism is surjective because those generators define the literal presentation. The group F_8 is residually finite, hence MF by Lemma 10.9. Theorem A shows that E is not MF. $\square$

10.4 A sofic non-MF group The Clifford witness has substantially more structure than was needed to prove $w \neq 1$.

Soficity does not imply MF. The group $W = \text{CLamp}(X) \rtimes V$ of Proposition 6.3 is a six-generated sofic group that is not MF. In particular, soficity does not imply the MF property. [formalized in Lean] Since every sofic group is hyperlinear, every sofic non-MF group is also a hyperlinear non-MF group. [formalized in Lean] Consequently W also shows that hyperlinearity — equivalently, Connes embeddability at the group level — does not imply MF.

Proof. Write $T = \varinjlim (\bar{\Gamma}, \bar{\alpha})$, so $V = T \rtimes \mathbb{Z}$, and let $B \leq V$ be the level-zero copy of $\bar{\Gamma}$. The image of $\bar{\alpha}$ has finite index (at most eight, by the parity classes of the translation lattice). Thus every telescope level $\bar{\Gamma}_n \leq T$ is commensurable with B . The stable letter conjugates B onto $\bar{\alpha}(\bar{\Gamma})$, so all of V commensurates B . Orbit-stabilizer now shows that every $\bar{\Gamma}_n$ -orbit in $X = V/B$ is finite.

Consider a finite subset of $\text{CLamp}(X) \rtimes T$. Its T -coordinates lie in one level $\bar{\Gamma}_n$. Each of its lamp coordinates has finite $\bar{\Gamma}_n$ -orbit: this holds for the central sign and for each site lamp, hence for every Clifford word. The finitely many resulting orbits generate a finite $\bar{\Gamma}_n$ -invariant subgroup $L \leq \text{CLamp}(X)$, because $\text{CLamp}(X)$ is locally finite. Our original finite set therefore lies in $L \rtimes \bar{\Gamma}_n$, which is sofic (finite-by-sofic). Soficity is local over finite subsets, so $\text{CLamp}(X) \rtimes T$ is sofic.

Reassociating the semidirect products gives

$$W = \text{CLamp}(X) \rtimes (T \rtimes \mathbb{Z}) \cong (\text{CLamp}(X) \rtimes T) \rtimes \mathbb{Z}.$$

The final group is sofic by permanence under extensions with amenable quotient [ES06]. Here $\bar{\Gamma}$ is sofic because its six matrices are integral and generate a residually finite linear group.

The map $E \rightarrow W$ of Proposition 6.3 is surjective: its image contains V , the root lamp c_o , and hence every lamp by transitivity of the V -action on X . Since E is generated by v_1, x, y, z, t, c (by the Tietze calculation above), their six images generate W . The map sends $w \in \text{Rad}_{\text{MF}}(E)$ to the nontrivial sign ζ ; portability (Lemma 10.2) makes $\zeta \in \text{Rad}_{\text{MF}}(W)$. Hence W is not MF. $\square$

Failure of extension permanence. MF groups are not closed under extensions. More precisely, W fits into an exact sequence

$$1 \longrightarrow \text{ClLamp}(X) \longrightarrow W \longrightarrow V \longrightarrow 1$$

whose kernel and quotient are MF, while W is not. The concrete lamp kernel is locally finite, LEF, sofic, and MF, while the total witness is finitely generated and non-MF. [formalized in Lean]

Proof. The Clifford lamp group is locally finite, hence MF by Lemma 10.10. The group V identifies with the subgroup of $\text{GL}_4(\mathbb{Q})$ generated by $\bar{\Gamma}$ and D : the direct-limit part embeds by injectivity of β , and the determinant records the $\mathbb{Z}$ -coordinate. It is finitely generated and therefore residually finite by Mal'cev's theorem [Mal]. Thus V is MF by Lemma 10.9, whereas W is not MF by the preceding construction. $\square$

An exact stably finite non-MF algebra. The same witness gives a concrete separable exact example: $C_{\text{red}}^*(W)$ is exact, has a faithful tracial state, is stably finite, and is not MF. Indeed, the locally finite lamp kernel is amenable and hence exact, while the linear group $V \leq \text{GL}_4(\mathbb{Q})$ is exact [GHW]. Exact groups are closed under extensions [KW2], so W is exact; for discrete groups this is equivalent to exactness of the reduced group algebra [KW1]. The canonical trace and stable finiteness follow as in Lemma 10.12. Finally, an MF embedding of $C_{\text{red}}^*(W)$ would restrict to a faithful norm-corona model of the canonical group unitaries, contradicting that W is not MF. All parts of this paragraph except exactness are also proved by a closed Lean endpoint; the present formal library has no definition of exact C^* -algebras.

A simple sofic envelope. There is a countable simple sofic group S_{simp} with

$$\text{Rad}_{\text{MF}}(S_{\text{simp}}) = S_{\text{simp}}.$$

Equivalently, every homomorphism from S_{simp} to an MF group is trivial.

Proof. By Elek–Szabó, every countable sofic group embeds in a countable simple sofic group [ES05, Theorem 1]. Embed W in such a group. Portability sends its nontrivial radical element ζ to a nontrivial element of the MF radical of the simple group. That radical is normal, so it is the whole group. Every homomorphism to an MF group kills the MF radical. $\square$

10.5 The reduced group algebra of E

Lemma 10.12. *Let G_1 be a countable discrete group.*

- (1) *The canonical tracial state τ on $C_{\text{red}}^*(G_1)$ is faithful.*
- (2) *Every unital C^* -algebra A with a faithful tracial state is stably finite: for every nonempty finite index set I , every isometry in $M_I(A)$ is a unitary. In particular this holds in $M_k(A)$ for every $k \geq 1$. [formalized in Lean]*

Proof. (1) Realize $C_{\text{red}}^*(G_1) \subseteq B(\ell^2 G_1)$ as the norm closure of the span of the left translation unitaries λ_g , and let ρ_g be the right translation unitaries, $(\rho_g \xi)(h) = \xi(hg)$; each ρ_g commutes with each $\lambda_{g'}$, hence with every element

of $C_{\text{red}}^*(G_1)$. The canonical trace is $\tau(x) = \langle x\delta_e, \delta_e \rangle$. If $\tau(x^*x) = 0$ then $\|x\delta_e\| = 0$, so $x\delta_e = 0$, and then $x\delta_g = x\rho_{g^{-1}}\delta_e = \rho_{g^{-1}}x\delta_e = 0$ for every $g \in G_1$. The vectors δ_g are total in $\ell^2 G_1$, so $x = 0$.

(2) On $M_k(A)$ the functional $\tau_k([x_{ij}]) = \frac{1}{k} \sum_i \tau(x_{ii})$ is a state with the trace property $\tau_k(xy) = \frac{1}{k} \sum_{i,j} \tau(x_{ij}y_{ji}) = \tau_k(yx)$, and it is faithful: the i -th diagonal entry of x^*x is $\sum_j x_{ji}^*x_{ji}$, so $\tau_k(x^*x) = 0$ forces $\tau(x_{ji}^*x_{ji}) = 0$, hence $x_{ji} = 0$, for all i, j . If $v \in M_k(A)$ satisfies $v^*v = 1$, then $y := 1 - vv^*$ is a projection with $\tau_k(y) = \tau_k(1) - \tau_k(vv^*) = \tau_k(1) - \tau_k(v^*v) = 0$; since $y = y^*y$, faithfulness gives $y = 0$, i.e. $vv^* = 1$. $\square$

Proof of Theorem D. $C_{\text{red}}^*(E)$ is unital and separable since E is countable; by Lemma 10.12 it carries a faithful tracial state and is stably finite. It is not an MF algebra by Theorem A. $\square$

11 THE CYCLIC-BASE CALIBRATION

Proof of Theorem C. As with w , the relator $w_{\text{BS}}^2 = 1$ is redundant — tct^{-1} and $\gamma_0(tct^{-1})\gamma_0^{-1}$ are involutions, so centrality forces it by (5) — and is retained only to display the marked pattern. Deleting it gives a six-relator presentation of the same group. The stable relation gives $t\langle\gamma_0\rangle t^{-1} \subseteq \langle\gamma_0\rangle$, and c centralizes this cyclic base. The same commutant argument as in Theorem B therefore maps w_{BS} to the identity in every finite-dimensional representation over every field.

For nontriviality, use the affine realization of $\text{BS}(1, 2)$ and its coset action. The root site is fixed by the cyclic base, while the two sites represented by t and $\gamma_0 t$ are distinct. Attach Clifford generators to these sites and map c to the root lamp. All seven relators hold, and

$$w_{\text{BS}} \longmapsto [c_{t\langle\gamma_0\rangle}, c_{\gamma_0 t\langle\gamma_0\rangle}] = -1.$$

Thus $w_{\text{BS}} \neq 1$. Restricting the target to the subgroup generated by the three displayed images gives the asserted surjective realized quotient. This comparison isolates the precise limitation of the finite-dimensional argument: exact finite-dimensional invisibility does not itself imply that the marked word is trivial. $\square$

Sharpness of the Kazhdan hypothesis. The realized Clifford quotient in Theorem C is amenable, hence MF, and its quotient map detects w_{BS} . In particular, $w_{\text{BS}} \notin \text{Rad}_{\text{MF}}(E_{\text{BS}})$, so property (T) cannot be omitted from the central-sign criterion. The affine group $\text{BS}(1, 2) \cong \mathbb{Z}[1/2] \rtimes \mathbb{Z}$ is solvable. The Clifford lamp group on its coset space is locally finite, so their semidirect product is amenable. The realized quotient is a subgroup of this amenable group and is therefore amenable, hence MF by [TWW]. Its marked word is the nontrivial Clifford sign by the calculation above.

This MF detector is necessarily genuinely approximate: neither the literal cyclic group nor its realized Clifford quotient is LEF, and the latter is not residually finite. Indeed, in every finite group the doubling relation makes the

image of $\langle \gamma_0^2 \rangle$ equal to the image of $\langle \gamma_0 \rangle$; the lamp therefore commutes with the required “halved” element and the marked word collapses. [formalized in Lean]

12 THE OPERATOR-NORM BOUNDARY

The proof is genuinely operator-norm in its present form. If multiplication is controlled only in normalized Hilbert–Schmidt norm, the induced adjoint operators on the Hilbert–Schmidt spaces need not be close in operator norm. They therefore need not define the Hilbert-ultraproduct representation to which the Kazhdan projection is applied. Equivalently, normalized Hilbert–Schmidt control does not supply the operator-norm spectral-subspace transport used in Theorem 2.1.

This identifies a boundary of the method, not a tracial nonapproximation theorem for E . Alekseev–Thom ask whether commutants arising in sofic approximations of Kazhdan groups can be recovered from finite-dimensional coordinate subalgebras [AT, Open Problem 6.2]. Such a coordinate description is separate from the operator-norm theorem proved here.

Questions The finite-normal mechanism has a precise torsion limitation: every finite subgroup of a torsion-free group is trivial. [formalized in Lean] Consequently a torsion-free example would require a different final obstruction, even if its transport step were similar. Fournier-Facio removed the analogous torsion obstacle for nonsocficity by a small-cancellation construction [FFF]. That strategy does not transfer directly here: the final operator-norm contradiction uses a nontrivial finite normal subgroup, which a torsion-free group cannot contain.

- (1) Is $E/\langle w \rangle$ MF? By Corollary 10.4, a positive answer would compute $\text{Rad}_{\text{MF}}(E) = \{1, w\}$ exactly. There is a concrete intermediate test. Theorem B kills $u = [tct^{-1}, v_1]$ in every finite-dimensional representation, whereas the image of u survives after quotienting the Clifford witness W by its central sign ζ : it becomes the product of the two distinct lamp basis elements at τo and $j(\bar{v}_1)\tau o$. Thus proving $W/\langle \zeta \rangle$ MF would already show $u \notin \text{Rad}_{\text{MF}}(E)$; any such detecting models must be genuinely non-finite-quotient in flavor.
- (2) Is there a torsion-free finitely presented non-MF group? The mechanism here is torsion-critical: the obstruction lives in a finite normal subgroup.
- (3) Is E sofic, or hyperlinear? The adjoint Hilbert-ultraproduct representation requires operator-norm multiplicative control, and neither property is decided by the results above.
- (4) Does MF imply hyperlinearity? A faithful embedding into a norm matrix corona need not make any coordinate trace faithful, so the defining MF representation does not immediately supply a hyperlinear model. This question concerns the CDE norm-corona convention fixed above; for stronger trace-controlled MF conventions the implication is built into the definition.

A PROOF OF THE MF EQUIVALENCES

An *operator-norm local model* for a countable group E , a finite set $F \subseteq E$, a separation constant $\delta > 0$, and a tolerance $\varepsilon > 0$ is a map $V: E \rightarrow \mathcal{U}(r)$, for some positive dimension r , such that

$$\begin{aligned} \|V(g)V(h) - V(gh)\| &\leq \varepsilon \quad (g, h \in F), \\ \|V(g) - V(h)\| &\geq \delta \quad (g \neq h \in F). \end{aligned}$$

The local formulation in Proposition 1.1 asks for such a model with $\delta = 1$ for every finite F and every $\varepsilon > 0$.

Proof of Proposition 1.1. Lemma 4.2 identifies the unitary-sequence quotient with the unitary group of the actual C^* -quotient. Replacing an arbitrary finite coordinate set by a standard set of the same cardinality merely conjugates that coordinate by a permutation unitary. This proves the first equivalence once the dimension convention is normalized.

Suppose first that $\rho: G \rightarrow \mathbf{U}_{\text{cor}}((d_n))$ is injective, and choose unitary lifts $u_n(g)$ of $\rho(g)$. Fix a finite set $F \subseteq G$ and $\varepsilon > 0$. For each ordered pair $g \neq h$ in F , injectivity says that $(u_n(g)^{-1}u_n(h))_n$ does not converge to the identity in operator norm. Hence there are $\delta_{g,h} > 0$ and arbitrarily large coordinates at which

$$\|u_n(g) - u_n(h)\| \geq \delta_{g,h}.$$

For each number $\delta_{g,h}$, compactness of

$$\{\lambda \in \mathbb{T} : |1 - \lambda| \geq \delta_{g,h}\}$$

gives an integer $M_{g,h}$ such that every point of this set has a power $1 \leq m \leq M_{g,h}$ whose distance from 1 is greater than 1. The quotient homomorphism law makes all multiplicative defects for pairs in F arbitrarily small at every sufficiently large coordinate. Choose, for each $g \neq h$, a coordinate with the displayed separation and with every required defect at most $\varepsilon/M_{g,h}$; then choose the corresponding power $m \leq M_{g,h}$. The m th tensor power separates the designated pair by more than 1, while the tensor-product telescoping identity bounds each new defect by $m\varepsilon/M_{g,h} \leq \varepsilon$. Finally take the block sum of these finitely many pair-specific models. Operator norms of block diagonal matrices are maxima, so every pair in F is separated by at least 1 and every required product has defect at most ε . This gives the normalized local model.

Conversely, enumerate the countable group and choose increasing finite sets F_n exhausting it. Apply the local condition to F_n with errors tending to zero. For each fixed g, h , the resulting unitary maps are eventually multiplicative on g, h , so their classes define a homomorphism into the unitary-sequence quotient. If $g \neq h$, both eventually lie in F_n and their distance is at least 1; their quotient classes are therefore distinct. The homomorphism is injective.

It remains only to normalize dimensions. Given positive dimensions d_n , choose recursively

$$D_0 = d_0 + 1, \quad D_{n+1} \geq \max\{d_{n+1} + 1, D_n + 1\}.$$

Pad every coordinate model by an identity block:

$$u_n(g) \mapsto u_n(g) \oplus 1_{D_n - d_n}.$$

The dimensions D_n increase strictly. Products, multiplicative defects, and pairwise operator-norm distances are unchanged, because the added block is the same identity representation for every group element. Thus the construction preserves and reflects the quotient relation and injectivity. Forgetting strict increase proves the converse. $\square$

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